

Singing Lesson: No Surprises

Radiohead / 1997 / ESL1 / sing-along, listening, discussion / three pages -- keep all three



Photo: Thom Yorke, 2013 (Wikimedia Commons, CC license).

The story of the song

Radiohead is a band from a small town in England. Their singer, Thom Yorke, writes songs about feeling tired, lost, or stuck in a loud world. He has a soft, high voice that can sound very sad and very beautiful at the same time.

This song is from their album *OK Computer* (1997), one of the most famous rock albums ever made. The song is a wish: for a quiet life, a pretty house, a small garden -- no alarms, no surprises. The music is gentle. It almost sounds like a lullaby. Today we listen, sing, and talk about what a quiet life means to us.

1. Before we listen (5 min, in pairs -- talk only)

- What does a *quiet life* look like to you? A small house? A garden? A morning with no phone?
- Some songs are loud and fast. Some songs are soft and slow. Which do you listen to more? Why?
- What is one thing in your day that gives you a small piece of quiet? Tell your partner.

2. First listen -- no lyrics (3 min, pencils down then circle)

What instruments do you hear? Circle them: piano guitar drums bells bass voice other: _____

How does the song feel? Circle them: calm sad sleepy tired soft quiet sweet other: _____

Thom Yorke's voice is very soft on this song. Why do you think he sings so quietly? _____

3. Second listen -- with lyrics (5 min). Underline any word you do not know.

Chords loop the same shapes: *F Bbm Bbmaj7/D Gm C Csus4*.

Verse (part 1)

F	A heart that's full up like a
Bbmaj7/D	landfill
Gm C Csus4	A job that slowly kills you
	Bruises that won't
F Bbm	heal
F	You look so tired and unhappy
Bbmaj7/D	Bring down the government
Gm C Csus4	They don't, they don't speak for
F Bbm	us

Verse (part 2)

F	I'll take a quiet life
Bbmaj7/D	A handshake of carbon
	monoxide and

Chorus

Gm C Csus4	No alarms and no surprises
Gm C Csus4	No alarms and no surprises
Gm C Csus4	No alarms and no surprises
F Bbm	Silent
F Bbm	Silent

Bridge 1 (then chorus)

F	This is my final fit
Bbmaj7/D	My final bellyache

Bridge 2 (then chorus, then *F Bbm F*)

F	Such a pretty house
Bbmaj7/D	And such a pretty garden

Words, then talk

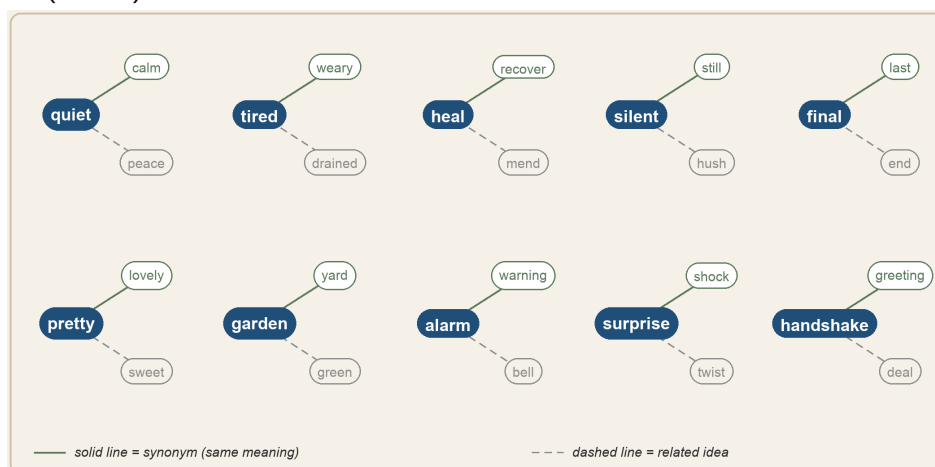
Build your vocabulary with the word map, then share what you heard.

4. Vocabulary warm-up

Quiet	with little or no sound; peaceful
Tired	needing rest; with low energy
Heal	to get better after being hurt
Silent	making no sound at all
Final	the last one; the end
Pretty	nice to look at; lovely
Garden	a small piece of land where you grow plants or flowers
Alarm	a loud signal that warns you of something
Surprise	something that you did not know was coming
Handshake	a greeting where two people hold and shake hands

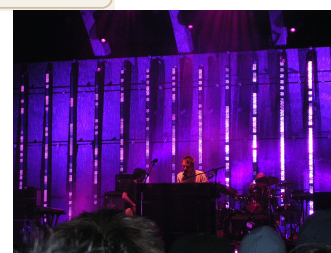
5. Word map

A *solid line* joins a word to a synonym (same meaning). A *dashed line* joins it to a related idea. Example: quiet -- calm (synonym) -- peace (related).



6. Discussion (10 min)

- What do you think this song is about? There is no wrong answer.
- The singer says, *I'll take a quiet life*. Would you take a quiet life? Or do you want a loud one, full of surprises?
- The song was written in 1997. Almost 30 years later, people still love it. Why do you think a song about wanting quiet still feels true today?
- Have you ever listened to Radiohead? Their most famous album is called *OK Computer*. Prof. Kramer's favorite song on it is this one. What is one song that gives you the feeling of calm?



7. Sing-along

Prof. Kramer plays guitar. Sing the chorus together. It is okay to be quiet. It is okay to be loud. It is okay to just hum.

8. Exit ticket (2 min)

In one sentence: what feeling did this song give you?

Behind the Song: Voices on Radiohead and *OK Computer*

Thom Yorke, his bandmates, and the journalists who covered the band, in their own words. Read first, then work through the questions at the bottom of the page.

The voices

"It is a song about wanting everything to stop -- the noise, the speed, the demands. Just for a moment. To take a quiet life. That is the whole wish."

- Thom Yorke, lead singer, on writing *No Surprises*

"We wanted the song to sound like a lullaby. Something you could almost fall asleep to. But the words are not gentle at all. That tension is the point."

- Jonny Greenwood, guitarist, on the album sessions for *OK Computer*

"For the video, Thom sat inside a glass helmet that slowly filled with water, holding his breath as long as he could. He did it in one take, again and again, until we had it."

- Grant Gee, director, on filming the 1997 music video

"OK Computer is a record about a world that moves too fast for the people inside it. Almost thirty years later, the album still sounds like a warning we are only now learning to read."

- Music journalist, looking back at the album

"When I first heard No Surprises, I was nineteen and very tired. The line I'll take a quiet life stayed with me for years. It was the first time a song had asked for what I wanted without me knowing I wanted it."

- Essayist, on hearing the song for the first time

Words to know

Word	Meaning	Word	Meaning
a wish	a hope; something you want to happen	a lullaby	a soft song to help a child sleep
tension	a feeling of two opposite forces pulling	a warning	a message that says: something bad may come
the demands	the things life or work asks of you	a take	one recording or one filming of something
to hold your breath	to stop breathing on purpose for a moment	to stay with you	to be remembered for a long time

Reading comprehension (write a sentence for each)

1. Yorke says the song is a wish for everything to stop. What three things does he want to stop? What word does the song use for the kind of life he wants instead?
2. Jonny Greenwood says the song sounds like a lullaby, but the words are not gentle. What is the *tension* he is talking about? Why might a band want that tension on purpose?
3. In the music video, what did Thom Yorke have to do, and how many times? What does this detail tell you about how the band makes its art?
4. The music journalist calls the album *a warning we are only now learning to read*. What do you think she means? What kind of warning could a song from 1997 still give us today?

Discussion (pairs or small groups)

- A. The essayist says the song *asked for what I wanted without me knowing I wanted it*. Has a song ever done that for you? What did it say, and what did you not know you wanted?
- B. The song is a wish for *no alarms and no surprises*. But surprises can also be good -- a gift, a phone call, a happy memory. Is the singer wrong to wish them away? Or is he just very tired?